

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Hairdressing and Barbering English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff.

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

02 Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

Use the same appearance and routine criteria for two styles.

03 Discussing color without promising a photograph

Describe a color preference while preserving genuine uncertainty.

04 Booking time and handling appointment changes

Negotiate appointments without disguising a timing conflict.

05 Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Ask a specific comfort question and acknowledge the answer.

06 Explaining services, prices, and product choices

Separate included services from optional additions.

07 Responding to a concern about the result

Repair an expectation mismatch without arguing or inventing a solution.

08 Passing preferences to the next appointment

Give a concise handover with an identifiable next task.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

SITUATION

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

consultation - A discussion with a client to establish the desired hair service, preferences, and limits.

reference photo - An image used to discuss a desired hairstyle, not a guarantee of an identical result.

perimeter - The outer outline of a haircut, including the visible line at the ends.

fringe - Hair cut to fall over the forehead; commonly called bangs in US English.

Useful word combinations

keep the length: retain the overall length the client identifies

take off the ends: shorten the ends by an agreed amount

frame the face: arrange the front shape around the face

agree on the outline: confirm the visible shape before starting

LESSON 01 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Ask about features, not just the whole photograph

3. Notice the language

A photograph contains several choices. Separate length, outline, and fringe; use an indirect question to find the feature the client means.

Which part of the photo would you like to keep?

When you say short, do you mean ___?

Could you confirm whether you want ___?

Compare this wording: I'll do it like the picture.

Clearer: You like the outline, but want more length and no fringe. Have I understood?

The revised response checks individual choices instead of assuming every detail is wanted.

4. Check the language

1. Client: I like the photograph, but I need a ponytail.

Stylist: Could you clarify ___?

A. which feature you do wants to copy

B. which feature want you to copy

C. which feature you want to copy

D. which feature do you want to copy

2. Client: Keep the front long; I don't want hair across my forehead.

Stylist: So you don't want a ____.

A. ponytail

B. fringe

C. perimeter

D. parting

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A bob photograph with a ponytail requirement

A first consultation before any cutting.

01 • Stylist: What appeals to you about this reference photo: the length, the fringe, or the outline?

02 • Client: Mostly the neat outline. I still need to tie my hair back at work.

03 • Stylist: The pictured length ends at the chin. That conflicts with your low ponytail requirement.

04 • Client: I hadn't noticed how short it was. Could we keep it near my collarbone?

05 • Stylist: Let's discuss that longer perimeter. Are you also asking for hair across your forehead?

06 • Client: No fringe, please. I wear glasses, and I like keeping the front tucked away.

07 • Stylist: So the photograph guides the outline, not the length or the front section.

08 • Client: Exactly. Could you show me the proposed length in the mirror before starting?

09 • Stylist: Yes, here is the point we discussed. Does this match what you meant?

10 • Client: It does. Keep that length, and leave the front long enough to tuck.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

What does a tidy-up include?

A barber clarifies a returning client's brief request.

01 • Barber: When you say a tidy-up today, which parts feel too long or untidy?

02 • Client: Around my ears, mainly. I'm growing the top out for a different style.

03 • Barber: Then shortening the top isn't part of your request. What about the neckline?

04 • Client: That needs attention too, but I don't want the whole cut much shorter.

05 • Barber: Understood. Your last appointment note says a short all-over cut; today's preference differs.

06 • Client: Yes, please don't use that old description. I've been growing it for weeks.

07 • Barber: I'll record that you're keeping the top and changing the outline around the ears.

08 • Client: Could you also check the back with me? I can't describe it very well.

09 • Barber: Certainly. We'll use the hand mirror to agree on the outline together first.

10 • Client: That helps. The top stays long, and we agree on the edges before starting.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Bangs and fringe mean the same area

A visitor uses a different regional word at the salon.

01 • Stylist: You mentioned bangs on the phone. Our booking note uses fringe; that's the same area.

02 • Client: Good, because I wondered whether I'd booked a completely different kind of haircut.

03 • Stylist: No, the words vary. What length do you have in mind across your forehead?

04 • Client: I want it below my eyebrows, not as short as the display photograph.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. Would you like the center and the sides discussed separately today?

06 • Client: Yes. I like longer pieces at the sides, but I don't know their name.

07 • Stylist: You don't need the technical name. Point to the areas you want to retain.

08 • Client: These pieces here. I usually tuck them behind my ears when I'm working.

09 • Stylist: I see. We'll keep those longer and confirm the center length in the mirror.

10 • Client: That's the distinction I was trying to explain. Please keep those side pieces.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Turning a reference photo into a clear request

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: you like the photo's neat outline, not its short length or fringe; you need a low ponytail.

Second round: The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Scenario 2 | Two photographs, one preferred feature

A client brings one photo for the back outline and another for the long front. Both show shorter overall hair than the client wants. The client needs shoulder length.

Role A: Stylist: identify one feature from each photo and confirm the retained length.

Role B: Client: choose the rounded back from photo A and long front from photo B; reject their overall length.

Possible opening: Can I combine the back from this picture with the front from that one?

Success checks

- Identify the chosen feature in each photo.
- Confirm shoulder length independently of the photographs.
- Restate the combined request aloud before proceeding.

Add a complication: The client calls both pictures 'the shorter one.' Ask them to point to A or B.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

Use the same appearance and routine criteria for two styles.

SITUATION

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

taper - A gradual change from longer to shorter hair, often around the sides and neckline.

fade - A haircut with a blended transition from very short hair to longer hair above.

layers - Sections cut at different lengths to create shape or movement within a hairstyle.

natural texture - The hair's usual straight, wavy, curly, or coily pattern without deliberate reshaping.

Useful word combinations

leave weight through the top: retain fullness in the upper part of the style

soften the outline: make the visible edge look less sharply defined

wear it natural: keep the hair's usual texture in the finished look

maintain the shape: preserve the agreed style between or during appointments

LESSON 02 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Compare the feature that matters

3. Notice the language

Names alone do not fix an exact length. Compare what is visible in the supplied images, then check the client's priorities without teaching a cutting method.

In this photo, ___, whereas in that one, ___.

Both give ___, but only this image shows ___.

How much time do you normally spend on ___?

Compare this wording: The fade is better.

Clearer: This image is shorter at the sides, whereas this one keeps more coverage.

The comparison identifies an observable difference instead of an unexplained ranking.

4. Check the language

1. Client: How do these two photographs differ?

Barber: This one keeps hair at the sides, ___ that one exposes skin.

- A. unless
- B. whereas
- C. because
- D. therefore

2. Client: I don't straighten my curls for work. What do you call my usual curl pattern?

Stylist: Your ___.

- A. natural texture
- B. overall density
- C. strand diameter
- D. current length

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Covered sides or a skin-level finish?

A barber compares two reference images with a client.

01 • Barber: These photographs show different side lengths. Which feature matters more to you today?

02 • Client: I want the neckline less bulky, but I don't want skin showing at the sides.

03 • Barber: In this taper photograph, the sides keep more coverage than in the skin fade.

04 • Client: Then the taper picture sounds closer. Does its name tell you exactly what I want?

05 • Barber: Not completely. We still need to agree on the visible length and overall shape.

06 • Client: I also have only five minutes in the morning, so elaborate styling won't suit me.

07 • Barber: How do you normally wear the top: brushed back, to the side, or natural?

08 • Client: Usually to the side with very little product. I want to keep doing that.

09 • Barber: We'll use the covered sides as our reference and discuss the top around that routine.

10 • Client: Yes, that comparison helps more than just choosing a haircut name from the menu.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Layers without losing the outer length

A salon consultation separates internal shape from the outside outline.

01 • Stylist: You asked about layers but also said the overall length must stay the same.

02 • Client: Right. I thought layers always meant making the whole haircut much shorter than it is.

03 • Stylist: Layers concern different lengths within the shape; the outside outline is a separate choice.

04 • Client: Can I have more movement without making it shorter overall?

05 • Stylist: Yes. Which reference image shows the kind of movement you're describing around the front?

06 • Client: This one does, though I don't like the very short pieces near the face.

07 • Stylist: That's important. We can discuss the longer sections without copying those shorter front pieces.

08 • Client: Please show me which parts you mean. I'm better with pictures than technical descriptions.

09 • Stylist: Here and here. Does that match your request to keep the outer length visible?

10 • Client: Yes, keep the overall length. Show me where the shorter layers would be.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The finish should reflect the usual curls

A client asks about a style photographed on straightened hair.

01 • Stylist: The reference photograph shows a smooth finish. Do you usually wear your hair straight?

02 • Client: No, I wear my natural curls almost every day and rarely spend time straightening them.

03 • Stylist: Then we should discuss how you want the shape to look with your usual texture.

04 • Client: I like the photograph's outline, but I wasn't asking for that exact straight finish.

05 • Stylist: Thank you for clarifying. Would seeing a curly reference help us discuss the same outline?

06 • Client: Yes, particularly at the sides. That's where I want the shape to feel less wide.

07 • Stylist: This second picture may be a better discussion point, although your result won't be identical.

08 • Client: I understand. I want a clear idea, not a promise that my curls will match.

09 • Stylist: Tell me what you like in this one, and we'll agree on those features.

10 • Client: The softer sides and retained top length are the features I'd like to discuss.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: prefer covered sides and less fullness at the neckline; you style for five minutes in the morning.

Second round: The client assumes 'low' means the same length in both photos. Clarify the actual area being compared.

Scenario 2 | A beard photograph with an unfamiliar label

A client requests a 'fade' after seeing a beard photograph. They mean a softer transition at the sideburns, not a shorter beard overall. The client likes the current chin length.

Role A: Barber: distinguish sideburn appearance from overall beard length.

Role B: Client: protect the chin length and point to the transition in the photograph.

Possible opening: When I say fade, I mean this part near my ears.

Success checks

- Identify the actual area in the photo.
- Keep overall beard length separate from the transition.
- Confirm appearance preferences without explaining tool techniques.

Add a complication: The client asks whether the service name alone guarantees the pictured result.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Discussing color without promising a photograph

Describe a color preference while preserving genuine uncertainty.

SITUATION

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

regrowth - New hair near the scalp that differs visibly from previously colored lengths.

tone - The warm, cool, or neutral color character seen in hair.

highlight - A section of hair made lighter than the surrounding hair.

color history - Information about previous color services and products used on a client's hair.

Useful word combinations

describe the regrowth: identify where the new growth is visible

review the color history: discuss previous products and services

compare color swatches: look at sample shades together

set realistic expectations: explain which result is still uncertain

LESSON 03 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Separate a desired shade from a confirmed service

3. Notice the language

A target shade is a request, not evidence of suitability. Identify missing history and keep the consultation separate from a service booking.

The photo shows ____; it doesn't establish ____.

We still need to know ____.

Today's booking covers ____, not ____.

Compare this wording: We can get that color by Friday.

Clearer: That is your target tone; the achievable result and timing still need assessment.

The revision preserves the preference without promising a technical outcome.

4. Check the language

1. Client: Is Friday's result already agreed?

Stylist: It remains ____ until your color history is reviewed.

A. unconfirmed

B. completed

C. unchanged

D. overdue

2. Client: I mean less golden, not necessarily lighter.

Stylist: You're asking about the ____ rather than simply the lightness.

A. gray coverage

B. highlight placement

C. regrowth length

D. tone

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A Friday target is not a confirmed result

A client attends a color consultation.

01 • Stylist: Your photo shows a cool tone. Is that what you want, rather than extra lightness?

02 • Client: Yes, especially before Friday. Can I book exactly that result for the party?

03 • Stylist: First we need your color history. Do you know which home product you used?

04 • Client: I remember the box being red, but I don't remember the product name.

05 • Stylist: That leaves an important detail unknown. The photo can't confirm what is suitable here.

06 • Client: I thought today's consultation included the color service. Was that my mistake when booking?

07 • Stylist: The booking is for discussion only. We haven't assessed the service time or cost.

08 • Client: I'll look for the packaging when I get home. Can we still discuss the target?

09 • Stylist: Certainly. We can identify your preferred tone without promising a particular result by Friday.

10 • Client: Then let's do that. I won't treat this consultation as a confirmed color appointment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Warmth is not the same as darkness

A client compares two salon shade samples.

01 • Stylist: You called both samples dark, but pointed to the golden one as your concern.

02 • Client: I struggle to describe it. The other sample looks calmer, even at similar depth.

03 • Stylist: Are you referring to the warm golden tone rather than how light it is?

04 • Client: Yes, that's closer. I don't necessarily want my hair made lighter this time.

05 • Stylist: Then we can discuss a less warm target without assuming a change in lightness.

06 • Client: Would calling it ash guarantee the exact shade on this sample ring for me?

07 • Stylist: No. The sample helps identify a preference; your own result needs an individual assessment.

08 • Client: That makes sense. Could you keep these two ideas separate in the consultation note?

09 • Stylist: Yes: less warmth requested, with no automatic request for lighter hair or new highlights.

10 • Client: That's the wording I needed. It avoids making the change sound larger than intended.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Remembering the missing appointment history

A stylist asks a returning client about an incomplete record.

01 • Stylist: Our note lists your last color visit. Is today's request about regrowth or the colored lengths?

02 • Client: The regrowth near my roots. I also used temporary color at home before my holiday.

03 • Stylist: Please include it in your history without guessing how it affects today's options.

04 • Client: I don't know the name, but my sister ordered it and may have the receipt.

05 • Stylist: That could help identify it. Shall we leave that part marked as unknown for now?

06 • Client: Yes. Please don't record that I haven't used anything just because I can't remember.

07 • Stylist: I'll state that a home product was used and its name remains unconfirmed.

08 • Client: Could we discuss haircut options today while the color question is still open?

09 • Stylist: We can discuss them separately. That doesn't decide whether a color service is suitable.

10 • Client: Good. I'll ask for the receipt, and today's conversation won't erase that missing detail.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Discussing color without promising a photograph

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: want a cooler appearance before Friday; you remember home coloring but not the product.

Second round: The client says the photograph proves it is possible in one visit. Explain the limit of that evidence.

Scenario 2 | A highlight request becomes an all-over question

A client booked a consultation about a few lighter sections but now wants the whole head to match a pale photograph. No service has been booked.

Role A: Stylist: distinguish selected highlights from the new overall request.

Role B: Client: want the pale appearance but cannot provide previous product details.

Possible opening: Does asking for highlights mean the whole head will look like this?

Success checks

- Separate highlighted sections from the all-over request.
- Identify the missing history.
- Keep service price and consultation price distinct.

Add a complication: The client assumes the consultation price is the price of either service.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Booking time and handling appointment changes

Negotiate appointments without disguising a timing conflict.

SITUATION

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

walk-in - A client seeking service without a booked appointment.

appointment slot - A period reserved in the salon schedule for a specified visit.

waiting list - A list of clients who want to be contacted if a suitable appointment opens.

service duration - The estimated time allocated to a particular salon service.

Useful word combinations

run behind schedule: begin later than planned

allow time for consultation: include discussion in the booking

offer a cancellation slot: propose time freed by another client

confirm the finish-time constraint: check when a client must leave

LESSON 04 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Offer a choice that fits the available time

3. Notice the language

State the delay and the client's departure separately. A shorter remaining window does not make the service itself shorter.

We are running ___ behind.

That would take us past ___.

Would tomorrow at ___ work instead?

Compare this wording: We'll squeeze everything in.

Clearer: Today's remaining window is too short for the usual service; tomorrow at ten is available.

The client can choose using an honest time comparison.

4. Check the language

1. Client: Must I stay until three?

Receptionist: With a 2:20 start and forty-minute service, the estimated finish is ____.

A. 2:40

B. 2:45

C. 3:20

D. 3:00

2. Client: Does joining the waiting list reserve a place?

Receptionist: It means we'll ____ if a suitable slot opens.

A. move your existing booking automatically

B. extend your existing service automatically

C. contact you

D. confirm your appointment automatically

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The departure time cannot move

Reception discusses the delayed 2:00 haircut.

01 • Receptionist: I'm sorry, we're running twenty minutes behind your two o'clock appointment this afternoon.

02 • Client: I need to leave by quarter to three. Is the full haircut still possible?

03 • Receptionist: The usual forty-minute service from 2:20 would finish around three, beyond your departure.

04 • Client: Could the stylist just work faster? I already arranged transport for today.

05 • Receptionist: I can't promise a compressed service. There is a full slot tomorrow at ten.

06 • Client: Tomorrow is possible, but would changing it count as my cancelling at short notice?

07 • Receptionist: This change is due to our delay; I can move it without a change fee.

08 • Client: Then please move it. I don't want to feel rushed through the consultation.

09 • Receptionist: You're booked tomorrow at ten for the full slot, and today's appointment is replaced.

10 • Client: Thanks for stating the timing clearly. I'll rearrange my ride for the new appointment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A walk-in between booked clients

A barber explains current availability to a visitor.

01 • Barber: Are you looking for a haircut today, or checking our next available booking first?

02 • Client: I was hoping to walk in. I can see an empty chair by the window.

03 • Barber: That chair has a booking starting shortly; an empty chair doesn't always mean available time.

04 • Client: I only need a small change. Could I take part of that appointment slot?

05 • Barber: We need enough time for the complete visit. The next open haircut slot is four.

06 • Client: I could return at four. Would I still have to join the walk-in queue then?

07 • Barber: If we book that slot now, you'll have an appointment rather than a queue place.

08 • Client: Let's do that. Can you confirm which barber I'm seeing when I return?

09 • Barber: You'll see Jordan at four. Please allow the full booked period for your visit.

10 • Client: Great. I'll come back for the appointment instead of waiting beside the empty chair.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An offer is not a booking

A salon receptionist calls a client on the waiting list.

01 • Receptionist: A cancellation has opened tomorrow at eleven. Are you still interested in that time?

02 • Client: Possibly, but I need to check whether my colleague can cover my shift first.

03 • Receptionist: I can hold this offered slot until four today while you check with them.

04 • Client: Does that mean it is already booked, even if I don't call you back?

05 • Receptionist: No. It is temporarily held; we need your confirmation before four to book it.

06 • Client: Understood. My colleague will be back at three, so I can answer after that.

07 • Receptionist: Would a call to this number be the easiest way to confirm your decision?

08 • Client: Yes. If I can't take it, I'd still like to stay on the waiting list.

09 • Receptionist: That's fine. Today's hold expires at four, but your waiting-list request can remain.

10 • Client: I'll call with a definite answer after three rather than assuming the hold is permanent.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Booking time and handling appointment changes

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: must leave by 2:45 today; tomorrow at ten is possible if today's complete service will not fit.

Second round: The client offers to skip the consultation. Keep the complete appointment's timing and assessment needs clear.

Scenario 2 | Two people, one online appointment

Two friends arrive under one forty-minute haircut booking. Only one service is reserved. A second full slot is available at five; the friends cannot both stay until then.

Role A: Receptionist: explain what is booked and offer a separate slot.

Role B: Client: keep your appointment; your friend can come tomorrow at noon, which is also open.

Possible opening: We put both our names in the note, so are both haircuts included?

Success checks

- Distinguish a note from a second booking.
- Do not halve the service time as an automatic solution.
- Confirm separate appointments and names aloud.

Add a complication: The client asks to divide the forty minutes equally.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Ask a specific comfort question and acknowledge the answer.

SITUATION

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

cape - A protective covering placed around a salon client's shoulders and clothing.

shampoo basin - A salon sink designed for washing a client's hair.

neck support - The part or accessory supporting a client's neck at a shampoo basin.

sensitivity - A client's reported tendency to feel discomfort or react to a product or contact.

Useful word combinations

check the water temperature: ask how the water feels to the client

adjust the seating position: change the chair arrangement for comfort

pause the service: stop the current activity to address a concern

report discomfort promptly: tell the stylist as soon as something feels uncomfortable

LESSON 05 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Make it easy to report discomfort

3. Notice the language

Invite a description rather than a yes-or-no endorsement. A comfort check is not a diagnosis or a technical treatment instruction.

Where does ___ feel uncomfortable?

I'll pause while we check ___.

Would you prefer to stop ___?

Compare this wording: It's fine, isn't it?

Clearer: How does the neck support feel for you?

The open question does not pressure the client to agree.

4. Check the language

1. Client: The support is pressing here.

Stylist: I'll ___ while we check your comfort.

A. speed up

B. sum up

C. pause

D. finish up

2. Stylist: Where does the cape feel tight?

Client: ___ my neck, especially at the front.

A. Throughout

B. Around

C. Across from

D. Beyond

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Pressure before the water starts

A stylist checks a client's comfort at the basin.

01 • Stylist: Before we start the water, how does the neck support feel in this position?

02 • Client: It presses at the back. I was hoping I could just ignore it briefly.

03 • Stylist: You don't need to ignore discomfort. I'll pause here while we discuss the arrangement.

04 • Client: Could I sit up first? It's easier to show you where the pressure is.

05 • Stylist: Of course. Tell me whether you want to leave the basin while we talk.

06 • Client: Yes, please. I'm sorry if that means the appointment takes longer than expected.

07 • Stylist: Thank you for telling me. We need your comfort feedback, not an apology.

08 • Client: Can the other chair be considered, or is this the only arrangement available today?

09 • Stylist: I'll ask my colleague to review the available setup with you before washing starts.

10 • Client: That's what I need. Let's keep the wash paused until we've discussed it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A cape that catches on a collar

A barber responds to a client's comfort request.

01 • Barber: Is there anything about the cape or chair you want me to check first?

02 • Client: The cape feels tight over my collar. Could we pause for a moment?

03 • Barber: Certainly. Is the pressure around the whole neck or mainly against the front?

04 • Client: Mainly the front, where the shirt button sits underneath the edge of the cape.

05 • Barber: Thank you. I'll stop preparing the cut so we can address that together.

06 • Client: I didn't want to interrupt after you'd started, so I'm mentioning it now.

07 • Barber: That's helpful. Please say something again if the arrangement still doesn't feel comfortable.

08 • Client: It already feels easier now that we've stopped. May I straighten my collar first?

09 • Barber: Yes, take your time. Then tell me how the cape feels before we continue.

10 • Client: My collar is settled now. Please check with me once the cape is back.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A fragrance preference is not a diagnosis

A client asks about a strongly scented styling product.

- 01 • Stylist:** Before discussing the finish, is there a product preference you want me to know?
- 02 • Client:** Strong fragrances bother me. I don't know whether that counts as an allergy.
- 03 • Stylist:** I'll note that sensitivity to fragrance. Which product's scent is bothering you today?
- 04 • Client:** The spray used nearby has a strong scent. I'd prefer not to use that.
- 05 • Stylist:** We can leave that product out while we discuss your preferences and the available alternatives.
- 06 • Client:** Could you tell me exactly which product you propose, instead of simply saying gentle?
- 07 • Stylist:** Yes. We can check its label together; I won't promise it cannot cause a reaction.
- 08 • Client:** I'd rather skip a finishing product today if we can't resolve my concern.
- 09 • Stylist:** Understood. No finishing spray today, and your concern remains described in your own words.
- 10 • Client:** Thank you. That choice is clear without putting a medical label on my preference.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: feel pressure at the back of the neck before washing; want to sit up and discuss comfort.

Second round: The client apologizes for slowing the appointment. Acknowledge the concern without minimizing the discomfort.

Scenario 2 | A quieter consultation

A client says the music makes the consultation hard to hear. A quieter chair is available, and reception can lower the music in the consultation area.

Role A: Stylist: offer the quieter chair and repeat the length request.

Role B: Client: prefer to move and want to see the stylist's face during discussion.

Possible opening: Could we go somewhere quieter before deciding on the length?

Success checks

- Do not treat the earlier nod as agreement.
- Offer the stated quieter option.
- Repeat and confirm the actual haircut preference.

Add a complication: The client nodded earlier but now says they missed the question.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Explaining services, prices, and product choices

Separate included services from optional additions.

SITUATION

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

service menu - A salon list describing available services and their stated prices or price ranges.

starting price - The lowest listed price for a service whose actual charge may vary with stated factors.

add-on - An extra service offered in addition to the originally selected service.

itemized receipt - A receipt listing individual services or products and their separate charges.

Useful word combinations

quote the total: state the price for the agreed scope

check what is included: establish which services a price covers

decline an add-on: choose not to purchase an optional service

break down the charge: explain the separate items making up a total

LESSON 06 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Explain the full price before agreement

3. Notice the language

Use a clear breakdown and ask for a choice. Avoid treating interest in an add-on as agreement to pay for it.

The price includes ___, but not ___.

Together, the total would be ___.

Would you like ___ alone or ___ as well?

Compare this wording: The finish is extra.

Clearer: The haircut is forty-five; adding the finish makes the total sixty.

The client can compare complete amounts.

4. Check the language

1. Client: Is the fifteen-dollar finish compulsory?

Stylist: No, it's ___.

A. complimentary

B. optional

C. inclusive

D. outstanding

2. Client: If I decline the fifteen-dollar finish, what remains in my forty-five-dollar booking?

Stylist: The haircut remains included; the finish ___.

A. is optional and separately charged

B. is included at no extra charge

C. has already been paid for

D. is required to receive the haircut

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The finish is a separate choice

A stylist explains a fictional menu before starting: haircut forty-five dollars, optional finish fifteen, and no additional charges.

01 • Stylist: The service menu lists your haircut at forty-five. Did you want the fifteen-dollar finishing add-on?

02 • Client: I thought the forty-five-dollar price covered both. What would the complete amount be?

03 • Stylist: Both services would be sixty dollars altogether, with no other charges added to that amount.

04 • Client: I can spend sixty, but I'd like to know what choice I actually have.

05 • Stylist: You can select the haircut alone for forty-five or add the finish for fifteen.

06 • Client: Then I'll take the haircut alone. I don't need the extra finish this afternoon.

07 • Stylist: Certainly. I'll confirm the haircut-only booking and won't add the optional service later.

08 • Client: Could I have an itemized receipt showing just the service I chose today?

09 • Stylist: Yes, it will list the haircut at forty-five, with no separate finishing charge.

10 • Client: That's clear now. Thank you for explaining the difference before I made the decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A starting price needs a specific estimate

A client phones about a service menu.

01 • Receptionist: You asked about the color consultation. Which part of the menu price needs clarification?

02 • Client: It says starting at eighty. Does that mean every color appointment costs eighty dollars?

03 • Receptionist: No. That's the starting price, not a quote for every possible color service.

04 • Client: What would I need before deciding whether a particular appointment fits my budget?

05 • Receptionist: The stylist needs to assess the requested service and explain a specific estimate.

06 • Client: Could I attend the consultation without committing to buy the service immediately afterward?

07 • Receptionist: Yes. Today's offer is a consultation, and its stated fee is separate from treatment.

08 • Client: Please tell me that fee too, so I can compare what I'm actually booking.

09 • Receptionist: The consultation is twenty dollars here. Any later service estimate would be discussed separately.

10 • Client: Then book the consultation only. I'll decide about a service after hearing its estimate.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A product quantity is not a discount

A client compares two sizes of styling cream.

01 • Stylist: These are the two sizes you asked about: fifty milliliters and one hundred milliliters.

02 • Client: The larger one costs more overall. Is it still cheaper for the same amount?

03 • Stylist: The small one is twelve dollars; the large one is twenty dollars for twice the quantity.

04 • Client: So two small containers would cost twenty-four, compared with twenty for the large one?

05 • Stylist: That's right for these displayed prices. Which size fits your likely use and budget?

06 • Client: The small one. I haven't tried it, and I don't want a bigger purchase today.

07 • Stylist: Certainly. Choosing the smaller size is fine even though its price per milliliter is higher.

08 • Client: Will buying it affect the haircut price or add anything else to my booking?

09 • Stylist: No. It's a separate twelve-dollar product purchase; your agreed haircut charge doesn't change.

10 • Client: Then I'll take one small container. Please list it separately on the receipt.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining services, prices, and product choices

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: assumed the finish was included; can spend sixty but want a genuine choice.

Second round: The client asks whether buying a product makes the finish free. No such offer exists in the supplied menu.

Scenario 2 | A beard service was not included

The haircut price is \$30; a beard trim is separately listed at \$12. The client requested both verbally but no total was agreed. Neither has started.

Role A: Barber: explain the \$42 combined price and the \$30 alternative.

Role B: Client: have a \$35 budget and prefer the haircut today.

Possible opening: I thought the beard trim came with the haircut.

Success checks

- Use the supplied prices only.
- Confirm the haircut-only choice.
- Do not imply the declined service will happen anyway.

Add a complication: The client asks whether a shorter beard trim has an unpublished lower price.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Responding to a concern about the result

Repair an expectation mismatch without arguing or inventing a solution.

SITUATION

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

adjustment - A discussed change to a completed hairstyle to address a specific concern.

service review - A salon discussion examining a client's concern and the possible response.

asymmetry - A difference in shape or apparent length between corresponding sides.

goodwill gesture - A discretionary service or benefit offered by a salon to acknowledge a problem.

Useful word combinations

identify the concern: ask what specifically differs from the request

check both sides: compare the visible result from agreed viewpoints

acknowledge the mismatch: recognize a difference between expectation and result

arrange a review: organize a discussion of the concern and possible response

LESSON 07 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Acknowledge the concern before proposing a remedy

3. Notice the language

Repeat the client's observation accurately. Discuss a review before promising an adjustment, price reduction, or particular result.

You're noticing ___ on ___.

Let's look at that area together.

We haven't yet agreed on ___.

Compare this wording: It looks fine to me.

Clearer: You're noticing a difference on the left; let's review that area together.

The response takes the observation seriously without claiming its cause.

4. Check the language

1. Client: The left looks longer than the right. What is that difference between corresponding sides called?

Stylist: That difference is ____.

- A. asymmetry
- B. overall length
- C. loss of volume
- D. color contrast

2. Client: Has a refund been agreed?

Receptionist: No; the stylist has agreed to a ____ first.

- A. completed refund
- B. price guarantee
- C. new purchase
- D. service review

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The left side looks longer

A client raises a concern before checkout.

01 • Stylist: You look uncertain about the result. Which area would you like to discuss together?

02 • Client: The left seems longer than the right. I expected the outline to look even.

03 • Stylist: Let's review the asymmetry you're noticing on the left before we continue with checkout.

04 • Client: Thank you. I wasn't sure whether mentioning it would sound as though I was complaining.

05 • Stylist: It's useful to be specific. Can you point to the section you mean?

06 • Client: This part near my jaw. In the front mirror it appears lower than the other side.

07 • Stylist: I see the area you're indicating. We should review the shape before discussing any adjustment.

08 • Client: Would that review automatically mean cutting more off both sides to make them match?

09 • Stylist: No. We haven't agreed on a change; we'll discuss any proposal with you first.

10 • Client: Please keep that distinction clear. I want to understand the options before losing more length.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A blunt message needs a correction

A receptionist repairs an earlier response to a service query.

01 • Receptionist: I said there was nothing we could do. That was too broad, and I'm sorry.

02 • Client: I took that to mean nobody would even listen to my concern about the finish.

03 • Receptionist: A service review is available. I should have distinguished that from a guaranteed refund.

04 • Client: I'm not asking you to decide the refund now. I want someone to hear me.

05 • Receptionist: The stylist can review your concern at four today. Would that time work?

06 • Client: Yes. Should I bring the photograph we discussed before the original appointment as well?

07 • Receptionist: Please do. It will help explain which part of the agreed look concerns you.

08 • Client: Will the review cost anything, or does booking it commit me to another service?

09 • Receptionist: The review is free. Any goodwill gesture needs the manager's agreement; no further service is booked.

10 • Client: Then four works. Thank you for correcting the impression rather than repeating the earlier refusal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A concern after a different home finish

A client returns with a question about the haircut's appearance.

01 • Stylist: Tell me what looks different today compared with the finish you saw in the salon.

02 • Client: The front sits flatter after I washed it. I thought the volume was from the haircut.

03 • Stylist: So the difference concerns how the front sits, not its actual length today?

04 • Client: Yes. I don't think more length has disappeared; it simply doesn't look as full.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. The salon finish and the underlying cut are different things to discuss.

06 • Client: I wish that distinction had been clearer. I assumed it would look identical every morning.

07 • Stylist: I'm sorry we didn't explain that expectation clearly. Let's review the look you wanted.

08 • Client: Could we discuss options without automatically booking a new cut or buying a product?

09 • Stylist: Absolutely. This conversation is a review of your concern, not an agreement to another purchase.

10 • Client: That helps. I'd like to understand the difference before deciding whether to change anything.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Responding to a concern about the result

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: the left appears longer; want to show the difference without being dismissed.

Second round: The client asks whether acknowledging the concern means the salon has approved a free adjustment.

Scenario 2 | The requested parting was misunderstood

A client requested a left-side parting but sees a center parting in the finish. No additional cutting has happened. The stylist can review the request now.

Role A: Stylist: acknowledge the specific misunderstanding and invite review.

Role B: Client: want the left-side appearance, not a shorter cut.

Possible opening: I meant a parting on the left, not through the center.

Success checks

- Name the parting concern accurately.
- Do not turn it into a request to cut more hair.
- Confirm what the client wants reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes the complaint is about haircut length.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Passing preferences to the next appointment

Give a concise handover with an identifiable next task.

SITUATION

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

client record - The salon's stored information about a client's visits and relevant stated preferences.

service note - A factual entry describing a salon service, discussion, or unresolved request.

rebooking - Arranging a client's next salon appointment.

handover - An exchange that passes relevant client information and outstanding tasks to another worker.

Useful word combinations

record a preference: preserve what the client actually requested

confirm the next visit: check the date, service, and person booked

pass on an open question: tell the next worker what remains unresolved

obtain photo permission: ask whether a client agrees to a specific use of an image

LESSON 08 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Keep preferences, requests, and bookings distinct

3. Notice the language

Use past tense for today's confirmed choices and request language for future interest. A note is not a booking or permission for another purpose.

Today the client chose ____.

They asked about ____; nothing is booked yet.

Please confirm ____ directly with the client.

Compare this wording: They want color next time.

Clearer: They asked about a color consultation; reception still needs to offer dates.

The next worker knows which action is missing.

4. Check the language

1. Receptionist: Is next month's consultation confirmed?

Stylist: No, the client has ____ about it.

A. attended

B. rescheduled

C. completed payment

D. inquired

2. Client: Can you save the photo for my next consultation but not post it?

Stylist: You're permitting ____ only.

A. all future publication

B. a social-media advertisement

C. the stated record use

D. public promotion

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A color inquiry reaches reception

A stylist hands a client visit over to reception.

01 • Stylist: Today's client kept the front length and chose no finishing spray. Please preserve both preferences.

02 • Receptionist: I've noted those. Is the color consultation already booked, or was it only discussed today?

03 • Stylist: Only discussed. The client asked about future dates, but hasn't selected one yet.

04 • Receptionist: Then I should offer consultation times, not describe the next visit as confirmed color treatment.

05 • Stylist: Exactly. Please check the client's choice directly rather than carrying a date over from another visit.

06 • Receptionist: Is there any permission for a promotional photograph with the new haircut this afternoon?

07 • Stylist: No permission has been given. Don't interpret the service note as agreement to photography.

08 • Receptionist: Understood. I'll ask only about booking times now and keep any photo request separate.

09 • Stylist: Please tell me which consultation date is accepted, or leave it clearly unbooked.

10 • Receptionist: I will. The next task is offering dates; neither color service nor photography is agreed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Keeping an internal photograph private

A stylist clarifies a client's limited photo permission.

01 • Stylist: Would you like a reference photo in your client record for the next consultation?

02 • Client: Yes, that would help me remember the outline, but I don't want it posted publicly.

03 • Stylist: So you're agreeing to the stated record use only, not social media or promotional material.

04 • Client: That's right. I saw the salon's photo display and wanted to make the difference clear.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. We'll handle the image under our record arrangements and note that limited permission.

06 • Client: Can I choose not to have any photo taken after all if I feel uncomfortable?

07 • Stylist: Yes. We can use a descriptive service note instead; a photograph isn't required for rebooking.

08 • Client: Actually, I'd prefer the note today. Please describe the retained length and the front shape.

09 • Stylist: No photograph today, then. I'll preserve those preferences in the note for the next stylist.

10 • Client: That suits me. I'm glad agreeing to an appointment doesn't require agreeing to a picture.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A new barber checks an old note

A covering barber discusses a returning client's recorded preference.

01 • Barber: Your previous note says short sides. Is that still what you want for today's visit?

02 • Client: Not this time. I'm growing the sides out and only want to discuss the neckline.

03 • Barber: Thank you. The old service note describes that visit, not a permanent instruction for every haircut.

04 • Client: Could you keep the older note but make today's changed preference clear for next time?

05 • Barber: Yes. Today's discussion will state that you're growing the sides and reviewing the neckline only.

06 • Client: There's also an old note about beard trimming. I don't want that service today either.

07 • Barber: I'll keep that separate. No beard trim is requested as part of this appointment.

08 • Client: Can we check the visible outline before anything starts, even though I'm a returning client?

09 • Barber: Certainly. Returning doesn't remove the need to confirm what you want on this particular visit.

10 • Client: Then let's look at the neckline together and keep both the sides and beard unchanged.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Passing preferences to the next appointment

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Receptionist: need to offer consultation dates and keep today's preferences separate from a future service.

Second round: The client consents to an internal reference photo but not publication. Repeat the limited permission.

Scenario 2 | A consultation time offered by voicemail

Reception offered Tuesday at noon but received no reply. The client arrives asking about a Friday slot instead; Friday at three is available.

Role A: Receptionist: distinguish the unaccepted Tuesday offer from a booking.

Role B: Client: prefer Friday at three and want confirmation by text.

Possible opening: Was Tuesday already booked just because you left that message?

Success checks

- Explain that suggested does not mean accepted.
- Confirm Friday at three directly.
- Keep the record clear about which offer was accepted.

Add a complication: A colleague's note says 'Tuesday suggested' without showing a response.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Editing example: You like the outline, but want more length and no fringe. Have I understood?

The revised response checks individual choices instead of assuming every detail is wanted.

Check 1: C - which feature you want to copy

A: 'You do wants' is not a grammatical verb form.

B: The subject 'you' must precede 'want' here.

C: Correct. The indirect question uses subject before verb.

D: Remove 'do' after 'clarify' in this indirect question.

Check 2: B - fringe

A: The client specifically needs to retain a ponytail.

B: Correct. A fringe falls across the forehead.

C: The perimeter is the overall outer outline.

D: A parting separates the hair into sections on the head.

Model response: Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

Editing example: This image is shorter at the sides, whereas this one keeps more coverage.

The comparison identifies an observable difference instead of an unexplained ranking.

Check 1: B - whereas

A: 'Unless' makes a condition that the photographs do not establish.

B: Correct. 'Whereas' contrasts the two appearances.

C: 'Because' would claim a cause, not a contrast.

D: 'Therefore' wrongly presents the second appearance as a consequence.

Check 2: A - natural texture

A: Correct. This refers to the usual curl pattern.

B: Density describes how closely hairs grow together, not their curl pattern.

C: Strand diameter concerns the thickness of individual hairs, not their pattern.

D: Length describes how long the hair is, not whether it curls.

Model response: In these photos, the low taper keeps more visible hair at the sides, whereas the skin fade exposes skin at the shortest area. You said you want less fullness at the neckline without that exposed look. Let's discuss the taper image as a reference and check how it fits your usual five-minute routine.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Discussing color without promising a photograph

Editing example: That is your target tone; the achievable result and timing still need assessment.

The revision preserves the preference without promising a technical outcome.

Check 1: A - unconfirmed

A: Correct. The outcome has not been established.

B: No color service has been completed.

C: There is no confirmed earlier result to keep unchanged.

D: No agreed result is late.

Check 2: D - tone

A: Gray coverage concerns how much gray is covered, not the golden tone.

B: Highlight placement concerns where lighter sections appear, not their warmth.

C: Regrowth length concerns new growth, not the color's warmth.

D: Correct. Golden describes warm tone.

Model response: The photograph helps us discuss the cool tone you prefer, but it doesn't establish what we can achieve by Friday. Your previous color product is still unknown. Today is a consultation; we need to review your color history before confirming a service, timing, or price.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Booking time and handling appointment changes

Editing example: Today's remaining window is too short for the usual service; tomorrow at ten is available.

The client can choose using an honest time comparison.

Check 1: D - 3:00

A: That allows only twenty minutes.

B: That is the client's departure constraint, not the estimated finish.

C: That adds an hour rather than forty minutes.

D: Correct. Forty minutes after 2:20 is 3:00.

Check 2: C - contact you

A: Joining this list does not authorize changing an existing booking.

B: A waiting-list entry does not automatically extend an existing service.

C: Correct. A waiting list offers contact if space opens.

D: An available slot still needs the client's acceptance before confirmation.

Model response: We're twenty minutes behind, and the usual forty-minute service would take us past your 2:45 departure. I can't promise to compress it into that time. Tomorrow at ten is available. Would you prefer that appointment, or to discuss another time that gives you the full slot?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Editing example: How does the neck support feel for you?

The open question does not pressure the client to agree.

Check 1: C - pause

A: Speeding up does not address discomfort.

B: Summing up means summarizing words, not stopping the activity.

C: Correct. 'Pause' means temporarily stop.

D: Finishing does not describe the requested immediate pause.

Check 2: B - Around

A: 'Throughout' refers to an entire area or duration, not the cape's position here.

B: Correct. 'Around' describes the cape surrounding the neck.

C: 'Across from' means opposite, not surrounding.

D: 'Beyond' means farther away, not surrounding the neck.

Model response: Please tell me where the support feels uncomfortable before we begin. We haven't started the water, and I'll pause here while we check the arrangement with you. You don't need to put up with discomfort to keep the appointment moving. Let me know whether you want to leave the basin.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Explaining services, prices, and product choices

Editing example: The haircut is forty-five; adding the finish makes the total sixty.

The client can compare complete amounts.

Check 1: B - optional

A: 'Complimentary' means free, but this finish costs fifteen dollars.

B: Correct. The client may choose or decline it.

C: 'Inclusive' concerns what a price covers.

D: 'Outstanding' would describe an unpaid charge or unfinished task.

Check 2: A - is optional and separately charged

A: Correct. Declining the separately priced finish leaves the haircut-only choice available.

B: The menu identifies a separate fifteen-dollar charge for the finish.

C: No payment for a finish has been made in this case.

D: The finish is optional, not a condition of receiving the haircut.

Model response: The forty-five-dollar price covers the haircut; the finish is an optional fifteen-dollar addition. Together they would be sixty dollars, with no other charges. You can choose the haircut alone for forty-five. Which option would you like me to confirm before we begin?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Responding to a concern about the result

Editing example: You're noticing a difference on the left; let's review that area together.

The response takes the observation seriously without claiming its cause.

Check 1: A - asymmetry

A: Correct. The client describes a difference between sides.

B: Overall length does not specifically name a difference between corresponding sides.

C: Loss of volume describes reduced fullness, not unequal side lengths.

D: Color contrast describes a shade difference, not a length difference.

Check 2: D - service review

A: This falsely states the refund is completed.

B: No future price guarantee was offered.

C: A review is not another purchase.

D: Correct. A discussion is agreed, not a financial remedy.

Model response: You were expecting an even outline, and you're noticing a longer-looking section on the left. I'm sorry this hasn't been addressed before checkout. Let's look at the area together with the stylist. We haven't agreed on an adjustment or refund yet; first we need to understand the specific concern.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Passing preferences to the next appointment

Editing example: They asked about a color consultation; reception still needs to offer dates.

The next worker knows which action is missing.

Check 1: D - inquired

A: Attendance would imply a visit took place.

B: Rescheduling implies an existing booking was moved.

C: No payment has been stated or confirmed in this scenario.

D: Correct. Asking about it does not establish a booking.

Check 2: C - the stated record use

A: This is broader than the client's permission.

B: Advertising is not the permitted consultation use.

C: Correct. Permission is limited to the described record use.

D: The client explicitly excluded posting.

Model response: Today's preferences were to retain the front length and leave out finishing spray. The client asked about a future color consultation, but no date is booked. Please offer available consultation times and confirm the choice directly. There is no agreement to promotional photography, so the visit note should not imply permission.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Barbers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/barbers-hairstylists-and-cosmetologists.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Hairdressers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/39-5012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Hairdressing and Barbering English

Professional audience: Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff

Scope: All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

Lesson 01: Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Original fictional case: A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Language workshop: Ask about features, not just the whole photograph

Communication goal: Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

Language guidance: A photograph contains several choices. Separate length, outline, and fringe; use an indirect question to find the feature the client means.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Which part of the photo would you like to keep? / When you say short, do you mean ___? / Could you confirm whether you want ___?

Vocabulary: consultation: A discussion with a client to establish the desired hair service, preferences, and limits. / reference photo: An image used to discuss a desired hairstyle, not a guarantee of an identical result. / perimeter: The outer outline of a haircut, including the visible line at the ends. / fringe: Hair cut to fall over the forehead; commonly called bangs in US English.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: you like the photo's neat outline, not its short length or fringe; you need a low ponytail.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Choose grammar that preserves the meaning

1. Use the lesson's language workshop, or one actual sentence from the dialogue, to explain a single grammar distinction in no more than 90 words. Show how it affects timing, certainty, responsibility or politeness.
2. Give one brief occupational exchange containing a gap and four complete options A-D. Supply enough context for exactly one answer. Keep distractors plausible; distinguish grammar errors from wording that changes the facts. Stop and wait.
3. Explain why each choice fits or fails, then ask me to read the completed exchange aloud. Do not request a draft, original written sentence or essay.
4. Repeat with three new exchanges, one at a time, moving from recognition to a more subtle meaning contrast. Do not copy the published checks. Label invented variations and do not turn uncertainty into a promise.
5. End with a short contrast table and two supported spoken turns using supplied frames. Accept accurate alternatives in oral practice; acknowledge and replace ambiguous multiple-choice items.

END PROMPT

Choose a clear message

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach guided workplace message choices

1. Use only the supplied reference and create one short, realistic dialogue with professional role labels and exactly one missing word or phrase. Supply four distinct options labelled A-D. Ensure that exactly one option fits both the grammar and the stated facts. Do not request a draft, an essay, or any open-ended writing. Stop and wait for my choice.
2. Use plausible distractors based on word combinations, certainty, timing, responsibility, or register. Avoid obviously absurd options. Do not introduce an unverified diagnosis, approval, deadline, charge, or legal rule. If extra fictional facts are necessary, state them explicitly before asking the question.
3. After I choose, identify the correct option and explain briefly why each of the other three options does not fit this exchange. Quote the relevant case fact or wording. Invite me to read both roles aloud; do not claim to assess pronunciation from a typed response.
4. Offer another four-choice exchange that practices a different expression. Present only one question at a time, wait for my answer, and vary the correct letter. If more than one answer is defensible, acknowledge the ambiguity and replace the question rather than marking a reasonable choice wrong.
5. After four exchanges, recap two useful word combinations and one distinction I should revisit. Ask which supported scenario I want to rehearse next, then stop and wait.

END PROMPT